



AI can do almost anything.

Now what? *(or can it actually do anything?)*

A working session on the skills that outlast the tool.

Pearl Nwade • Senior Data & Analytics Engineer • MSc FinTech, back where it started

WHERE I'M COMING FROM

Last year I stood here with a different talk.

2025

“How I went from finance to data engineering.”

A story about acquiring a skill. Learn the tools, get the job.

2026

The skill itself just got cheap.

AI can write the code, build the model, write the docs. So what's left that's actually yours?

Let's be honest about the question you're all asking.

If AI can do everything, why do I still need to be **the** **engineer?**

I spent the last month letting AI do almost everything on a real project. Here is exactly where it stopped being enough.

THE REAL SHIFT

AI didn't replace the work. It raised the floor.

Anyone can now produce something. The question is whether the something is right.



Producing output

BEFORE Scarce, slow, the bottleneck

NOW Cheap, instant, commoditised



Knowing what to produce

BEFORE Assumed once you could code

NOW The new bottleneck. The scarce thing.



Three times it confidently got it wrong.

Real moments from one project, where the tool produced something plausible and the judgment had to catch it.

WHERE THE TOOL STOPPED

The work was done. The thinking wasn't.



It looked right

A confident answer that would have quietly corrupted every revenue number. Plausible is not the same as correct.

DOMAIN JUDGMENT



It went missing

Something important silently dropped out during edits. The tool never noticed. Only a human audit caught it.

KNOWING WHAT 'DONE' MEANS



It didn't transfer

Clever logic from one context was wrong in another. Knowing that needs taste and experience, not pattern-matching.

CONTEXT & TASTE



The pattern under all three

**AI gives you the answer.
It can't tell you if it's the *right*
answer.**

That gap, between an answer and the right answer, is where your degree lives.

The skills that sit above the tool.



Asking the right question

AI answers what you ask. Framing the actual problem is still yours.



Knowing when it's wrong

Confident and wrong looks identical to confident and right. You need the judgment to tell them apart.



Domain understanding

Why a number means what it means. AI has the syntax; you bring the meaning.



Deciding what NOT to build

The discipline to skip the impressive-looking thing that nobody needs.

Stop asking AI to drive. Start being the driver.

Passenger

“Write me a model.”

- Takes the output on trust
- Can't tell good from plausible
- Ships what the tool gave them

Driver

“Here's the problem and the constraints.”

- Directs, reviews, overrides
- Owns every decision the tool can't make
- Ships what's actually right

FOR THE NEXT 48 HOURS

The winning team won't generate the most code.

It'll understand the problem best, and make the sharpest calls about what to build.



Use AI to go fast

Scaffold, draft, explore. Let it raise your floor. Don't romanticise doing it by hand.



Use judgment to go right

Question the output. Check the thing that looks too clean. Decide what to cut.



Be the driver

The tool is brilliant and tireless. It still needs someone who knows where you're going.

Interactive session

I need a volunteer

Use AI to write the requirements for a new feature: a fraud alert that warns us when a customer's transaction looks suspicious. Ask it to give you the full spec.

AI is the most powerful tool you'll ever use.

It is not the driver.
You are.

Go build something only you would have known to build.